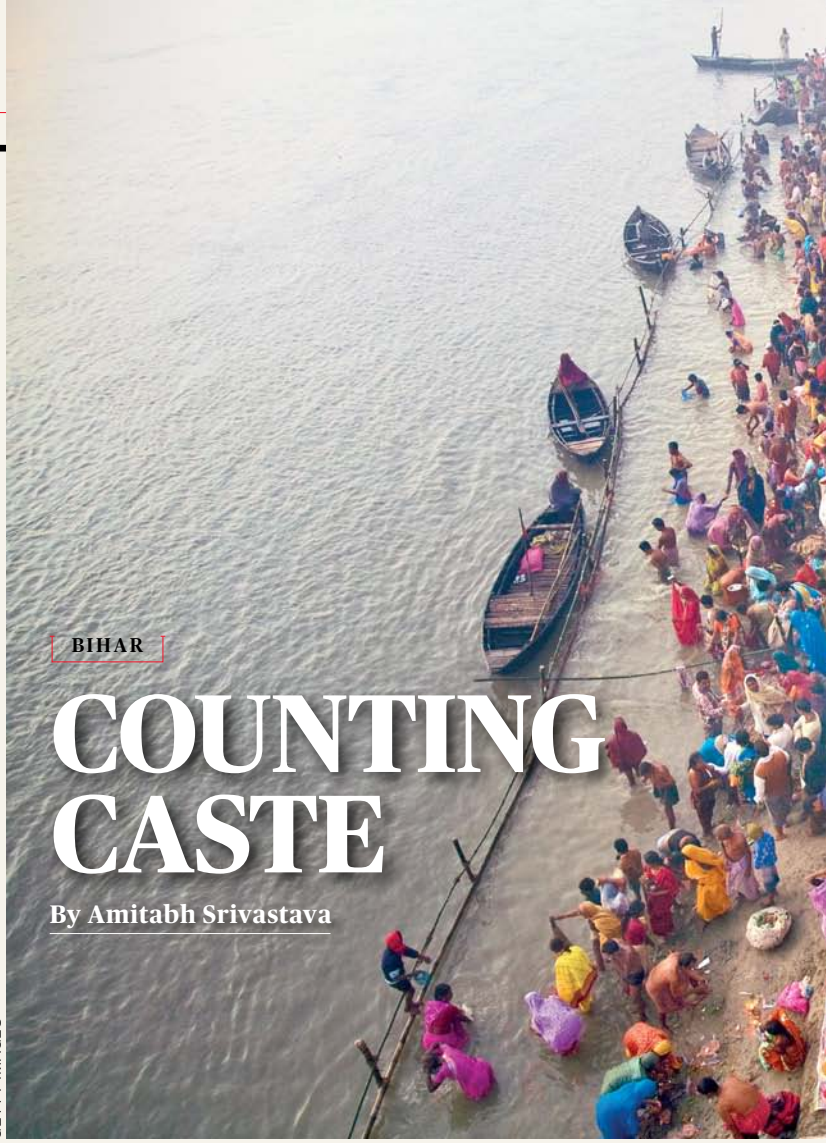
BSP is abstaining: that leaves open the chance of Dalit votes shifting to the BJP.

Dr Shilp Shikha Singh, assistant professor at Lucknow's Giri Institute of Development Studies, feels Akhilesh may lack the momentum he managed to build before the assembly election with the vision of an upset win. "His biggest challenge is to live up to those expectations while fighting from the opposition space. The BJP has the advantage of being in power. And there are visible cracks in his support base."

It's at this delicate juncture that Shivpal and Azam are increasing the unease for Akhilesh. The first anyway has a long history of see-saw ties with Akhilesh: he had even walked out of the SP in 2017 over growing differences. A rough-hewn patch-up was effected in the run-up to the assembly polls, and Shivpal's party contested as part of the SP-led alliance. Shivpal himself contested from Jaswantnagar, in Etawah district, as an SP candidate. But he again felt estranged when Akhilesh did not invite him for a key meeting of SP leaders in Lucknow. Azam, for his part, seems to be sulking—that he did not field anyone from his family in Rampur is a dead giveaway. He resorted to some roundabout rhetoric on this, asking what reason a "poor man" like him would have for being upset. But sources close to him tell INDIA TODAY that he is indeed unhappy with the high command. Azam, who held immense sway in the party during the SP rule, was released from Sitapur jail only on May 20, after spending 27 months in judicial custody in dozens of cases.

The BJP, while keeping an eye on the words and deeds of the troubled duo, is continuing its OBC focus for the bypoll. Bhojpuri actor-turned-politician Dinesh Lal Yadav 'Nirahua' is its man for Azamgarh, and former SP MLC Ghanshyam Lodhi has been named for Rampur. SP spokesperson Zeba Yasmeen says her party is not spooked by those names. "Nirahua is a non-serious candidate, the public won't support him," she says. But can Akhilesh get that wind in his sail again? ■



GETTY IMAGES

BIHAR

COUNTING CASTE

By Amitabh Srivastava

On June 2, as the Nitish Kumar-led cabinet decided to conduct a caste count of Bihar's 120 million people, it was apparent that the chief minister had arm-twisted alliance partner BJP to get them onboard. A day before, the Bihar chief minister had held an all-party meeting of the legislature on the issue, where BJP state president Sanjay Jaiswal and the deputy CM from the party, Tarkishore Prasad, joined the others in unanimously deciding in favour of a caste count. Clearly, as a senior BJP leader who preferred to stay anonymous put it, the party is determined to "put an end to any impression suggesting that it wanted to stall the caste count".

Now this is contrary to the BJP-ruled Centre's stated position on the issue. In July 2021, Union MoS for home Nityanand Rai had declared in the Lok Sabha that the Centre is averse to a national caste census of the population.

In Bihar, the Nitish government will set aside Rs 500 crore for the census, which will include all socioeconomic details. The deadline to complete the exercise is February 2023. Analysts say the caste-wise enumeration—the findings will be placed in the public domain—could result in a massive social churn, with the dominant caste groups expected to make a play for a bigger slice of power.

"The downside is, it may create fresh cracks and social tensions in an already fragmented society. New caste alliances could crop up, which could be to the detriment of the BJP," says a senior Janata Dal (United) leader in Patna.

The timing is crucial too—the results will become public just a year before the 2024 Lok Sabha election. Any social churn, emergence of new caste hegemonies or resurgence of